

PROLOGUE

You are twelve years old.

The hallway is cold. The cold climbs through your soles and threads into your calves like wire pulled through a hem. Your legs want to run. Your legs are sewn to the floor. The window at the end of the hallway is open. Wide open — the brass casement pushed out to its fullest, the way it only stays when the coastal wind catches it right. The night is warm but the hallway is cold. The air moves through the window and past you. Salt. Eucalyptus. And underneath, something metallic and sharp — a taste like a coin pressed flat against your tongue. A smell you will carry for twenty-five years without knowing its name: chamomile and honey, steeping on a stove somewhere below.

You hear your own heartbeat — something caged, throwing itself against your ribs. You hear the house breathing around you — the creak of timber, the rattle of a windowpane somewhere, the particular silence of a building full of sleeping people, the silence that collects in hallways at two in the morning like breath held past the point of comfort. And then you hear a voice. Low. Female. Not yours. The words are not clear but the tone is. A command. Sharp. The kind of tone that makes your shoulders climb towards your ears and your breath freeze halfway down your throat like a swallowed stone.

Two figures at the end of the hallway.

The light is not on and the light is not off. A grey half-light from the open window that builds shapes and withholds their details. One figure is tall. One is small. They are close to the window. They are close together. The tall one's back is to you. The small one is facing the glass. The sill is low — low enough for a child to reach, low enough that the open casement is an invitation to the dark beyond, and the dark is three storeys above the ground.

The tall figure's arm moves.

Not fast. Not a swing. A push. Deliberate and controlled. The small figure stumbles backward. Arms reach out — not towards the tall figure but towards the window

frame. Fingers splay. Nails catch wood. A sound, small and high, like a gasp cut in half. Like breath choosing a direction and choosing wrong.

Then the window is empty.

Not falling. Not jumping. Gone. Through the open window and into the dark beyond. The air where the small figure stood is suddenly empty. The window frame is bare wood and moonlight. The fingers are not there anymore.

The air changes. The salt and metal go out of it, and what remains is the hollow a room makes when someone has just left it — a silence so total it has a weight, the loudest thing you have ever not heard.

You are at the window. You don't remember walking. The grass below is dark and wet, and something is on it — something small, something that was a figure, then a shape, then a stillness, and the stillness is louder than any scream.

The tall figure is beside you. You didn't hear her approach. Her hand is on your shoulder. Warm. Firm. The warmth of a palm that has just done something terrible and has not yet stopped being warm. Her voice is close to your ear and she says words — low, unburied, each one placed the way you set down something fragile.

And then a camera flashes, somewhere in the dark behind you. A sharp white burst that freezes the hallway for one-thousandth of a second — the tall figure, the empty window, the small face turned towards the light. Somewhere in the house a shutter has closed on a frame of film. It will sit in the dark for a long time. It will wait for someone who knows to look.

The window is empty. The grass is dark and wet and the salt air carries the silence away from the house. Whatever was here is leaving. What stays, stays in the body. You are twelve years old. And you are Rowan Thorne. And you have been standing here ever since.

CHAPTER 1

NEVE

The Drive

My mother taught me everything. How to hold a knife. How to fold a shirt. How to answer a question without answering it.

I left Lily at the kitchen table with her homework. She looked up when I put my bag by the door. "Do you have to go this weekend?" Twelve years old and she already knows the tone that means the answer is yes, don't ask again. She gets it from me. I get it from my mother.

I knelt beside her. Brown eyes, Liam's eyes, watching me with that particular twelve-year-old intelligence that knows when an answer is a door closing. "Just for a couple of days, sweetie." The words came out steadier than I deserved. I tucked a strand of hair behind her ear. She didn't pull away but her shoulders stiffened under my hand — small, bird-thin shoulders that carried the weight of a question she knew better than to ask twice.

"I'll be back Sunday night, I think," I said.

Liam was at the counter making sandwiches for her lunch. He looked at me over her head — the question he wasn't asking written across his face. He stopped asking about my childhood years ago. He knows there's a room in me he can't enter and he has agreed, without ever saying so, not to knock. He married me anyway. I don't know if that's kindness or resignation. Probably both.

"She'll be fine," Liam said. He meant Lily. He always means Lily when he says "she'll be fine." Fine. The word follows me through my

life like a scar I've stopped trying to see.

At the door I turned back. Liam wrapping the sandwiches, Lily bent over her homework, the kitchen warm and golden and everything a kitchen should be. I almost said it. The words were right there — there's something I've never told you — my hand on the doorframe, knuckles white, the sentence pressing upward like something drowning. Then Lily looked up. "Drive safe, Mum." And the words went back to the locked room, and I closed the door, and I left.

I didn't kiss her forehead. I should have. I don't know why I didn't.

The sky was grey. Low cloud over Melbourne, the kind that presses down on the city like a hand on a chest. The GPS said an hour and eleven minutes south and the further I drove the greyer it got, the cloud thickening over the peninsula as if the sky knew where I was going and was bracing for it. The radio said a cold front was moving through from the southwest. Heavy overnight rain. Strong winds. The kind of winter weather that closes roads and cuts power to coastal towns and reminds everyone who lives near the sea that the sea does not care about your plans. I turned the volume down. I didn't need the forecast. The sky was already telling me.

I stopped for petrol at Rosebud. The servo was on the main road, the last one before Sorrento, and I'd been here before — my hands knew the pump, my feet knew the concrete, the way your body knows places your mind has agreed to forget. Inside, the man behind the counter was sixtyish, weathered, the kind of face that has spent decades being shaped by coastal wind.

"Heading down to Sorrento?"

"Just for the weekend."

He handed back my card. "Bit isolated down that end this time of year. You take care."

I took my card and I left and the bell above the door rang once, sharp, the way bells ring in empty shops in coastal towns in winter, and I drove on.

I turned the heater on. The fan pushed warm air through the vents and with it came a smell — faint, green, sharp at the edges. Eucalyptus. The car's air freshener, probably. Some tree-shaped cardboard thing

hanging from a rear peg that I'd never noticed. Except the smell wasn't coming from behind me. It was coming through the vents. From outside. The peninsula air. Salt and eucalyptus and something underneath both — something metallic, something my body knew before my mind caught up. My jaw locked. My hands tightened on the wheel. The smell was the smell of that night. The smell of the hallway. And it was everywhere.

I should turn it off. I don't. The voice — calm, female, Australian — tells me to take the next exit, and I follow her instructions even though I'd taken this turn a hundred times before I was thirteen. My hands are on the wheel at ten and two, the way she taught me.

The reunion was Saskia's idea. At least, the email came from Saskia's address — a weekend at the house in Sorrento, the five of us, after twenty-five years. I didn't want to go. I told Liam it was a bad idea and he said "Then don't go," which is the logical response, the healthy response, the response I would give a client. Don't do the thing that frightens you unless there's a reason. I didn't have a reason. I couldn't name one. But the email arrived and my hands shook when I read it and I said yes before I'd decided, which means some part of me decided before I did.

I've spent fifteen years sitting across from people in carefully arranged rooms, helping them face the things they're afraid of. Families torn by divorce. Children who won't speak. Parents who sit on opposite ends of the sofa and look at me instead of each other. I'm good at it. I'm very good at helping other people map their patterns. My own patterns I keep in a locked room at the back of my mind, behind a door I have never once opened. I know it's there. I built it myself. That's the thing about denial — it requires tremendous skill to maintain. My clients think they're bad at avoidance. They're amateurs. I'm a professional.

My phone buzzes on the passenger seat. Mum. I answer on the second ring.

"How far are you?"

"About forty minutes."

"You don't have to do this, sweetheart."

"I know."

"Sometimes it's better to leave things where they are."

In the background I hear the murmur of the hospice — a television playing something nobody is watching, someone's call bell drilling through the corridor, the particular acoustic of a building designed for people who are checking out one by one. Mum has been there three weeks. Pancreatic cancer. Stage four. She told me herself, sitting in her kitchen with a cup of tea, as calm as if she were reading someone else's test results. "It's treatable but not curable," she said. Only my mother could deliver her own death sentence in the passive voice.

"So — you're comfortable?" I ask.

"Don't worry about me. Worry about you."

"I'm not worried about me, Mum. I'm fine."

A pause. The hospice sounds are distant and immediate at once. "You were always the brave one, Neve. But brave isn't the same as ready."

I don't know what ready would feel like. I don't know what I'm going back to. A house. Four women I haven't spoken to in twenty-five years. A weekend that was — that was a long time ago. I was a child. I don't remember much about that holiday. I was twelve. I slept through most of it, apparently. I was always falling asleep in cars, in the afternoons, on the couch. My mother says I slept through the whole holiday.

"Neve? Are you still there?"

"I'm here, Mum."

A pause. Then, softer: "I'm proud of you, sweetheart. I know I don't say it enough. The way you are with Lily. The way you've built your practice. You turned out exactly the way I hoped you would."

The words arrive warm and unexpected, the way her love always arrives — sudden, disarming, landing in the place where the wall is thinnest. My eyes sting. I blink hard at the road. This is what she does. She spent twenty-five years telling me what to remember and she spent the same twenty-five years loving me with a ferocity that makes it impossible to separate the love from the control, because they grew from the same root and they share the same soil and I cannot cut one

without killing the other.

"You'll call me when you get there?"

"Yes. I think so."

"And if it gets to be too much —"

"Mum. I'm fine."

I say it the way I always say it. The way she taught me to say it. Fine. Such a useful word. It means nothing and it means everything and it means stop asking. She hears it the way I mean it — stop asking — and she stops. The phone goes quiet. The GPS talks. The road opens. The sea appears on my right, grey and flat under a winter sky.

The smell of her kitchen rises without warning — chamomile and eucalyptus steeping on the back burner, the blend she made for us when we were small and couldn't sleep, the blend that meant everything was fine, the blend that meant close your eyes, the blend that meant Mummy's got this. The smell is not here. The smell is twenty-five years ago. My throat tightens around it the way it tightens around everything she has ever given me.

The last time I drove this road I was twelve and the sea was blue and my mother was driving and I was in the back seat with my best — I was in the back seat. I don't remember who was in the back seat with me. I don't remember the drive at all. I was probably asleep. I was always asleep. My mother says I slept through the whole holiday. She says it the way she says everything — with certainty, with authority, as if she is reading from a record that cannot be disputed. And because I don't remember otherwise, I believe her. I have always believed her.

Something lifts in my chest. Not a memory. Not quite. A sensation — salt air and creaking floorboards and light, golden light, the kind of light that makes everything look like it's keeping a secret. A holiday. A summer holiday. I was happy. I think I was happy. The sensation is warm and full and then it's gone, replaced by a contraction behind my sternum — the kind I could map on a whiteboard for any client but cannot name in myself.

Anticipation. That's what it is. The body can't tell it from anxiety. They produce the same physiological response: elevated heart rate, shallow breathing, muscle tension. I learned this in my first year of

training. I've taught it to a hundred clients. The mechanism doesn't change because the body it's happening to is mine.

The GPS says eleven minutes. My hands are shaking on the wheel. I register this the way I register things in my clients — from a distance, clinically, as if the hands belong to someone else. Essential tremor. Caffeine. Low blood sugar. I haven't eaten since breakfast. That's all this is. I know what hypoglycaemia looks like. I know what anxiety looks like. This isn't anxiety. I'm not anxious. I'm fine.

The sea now — salt and something else, something underneath, something nameless that closes my throat like a hand around a pipe. My chest tightens. I tell myself it's the heating. The car is too warm. I turn the heating off.

The GPS says seven minutes. The road narrows. The houses begin — holiday homes, weekenders, painted in the soft coastal palette of blue and white and grey. I know this road. I don't remember learning it but I know it the way I know the lyrics to a song I can't remember hearing. Left at the war memorial. Right past the newsagent. Straight through the roundabout. The GPS confirms what my hands already know.

The house appears before the GPS tells me to turn.

Different colour — it was white, now it's a blue-grey. The porch is wider. The garden gate is new. The front garden has been landscaped — native grasses, stone paths, the orderly minimalism of a property styled for rental. But the roofline is the same. The angle of the eaves. The position of the upstairs windows. The shape of it against the sky is the same and my grip tightens on the wheel and the car is too close and I'm not ready and —

I pull into the driveway and stop the car.

I sit for a long time.

The house is just a house. It's been renovated. Someone has lived here, changed it, painted it, made it theirs. It's a holiday rental now. We're renting it for the weekend — Saskia arranged it, or said she did. It belongs to strangers. It's just walls and a roof and windows and a floor.

A band of pressure wraps around my ribs like a blood-pressure cuff inflated past the point of comfort and kept going. My lungs can't

expand.

I sit in the driver's seat and I breathe the way I teach my clients to breathe. Four in, seven hold, eight out. Four in, seven hold, eight out. The breath goes in and the breath goes out and the house stays where it is. You are safe. You are in control. The past is not happening now. The past is a story we tell ourselves, and the story can be rewritten. I believe this. I have built my career on this belief. Memory is not a recording. It is a reconstruction — every recall builds the scene anew, and every witness rebuilds the room a little differently. I teach this to my clients. I have never once applied it to myself. The house is just a house.

My hands are still shaking. I press them flat against the wheel and hold them there until the trembling stops.

Five minutes. I count them on the dashboard clock. Five minutes of breathing and not looking at the upstairs windows and telling myself the things I tell people in my office every day. The mind cannot distinguish between a real threat and a perceived threat. The amygdala responds to both identically. What you're feeling is not a memory. It's a physiological response to a stimulus. Name it and it loses power.

It doesn't lose power.

My phone buzzes. A text from Mum: "You don't have to do this."

I text back: "I know. I'm already here."

I don't get out of the car. I sit and I look at the house and I wait for something — a feeling, a memory, a reason to turn around. Nothing comes. The house is beautiful now. Rendered walls, wide porch, black gate — the kind of holiday house you'd rent for a weekend and photograph for Instagram. Someone has planted jasmine by the front door. It's flowering, white stars against dark green, and the smell is sweet and clean and it shouldn't be here. This house should smell of salt and old wood and something darker underneath. The beauty is a lie. The beauty is the fresh tablecloth pulled over the stain.

I get out of the car.

My legs are shaking — a fine tremor in the quadriceps that I register without looking, as if not seeing it might make it not real. I lock the door and stand in the driveway and the sea air hits me and there it is — salt and wood and underneath it a sweetness, a warmth, like sun on

old timber. The house is just a house. It's just a house.

I lift my bag from the back seat and the weight of it grounds me. Something to hold that isn't the steering wheel. Isn't the door handle. Isn't my own wrist. I walk towards the front door. My knees want to buckle and I keep walking because my knees do not get a vote. I have helped hundreds of people walk towards the things they're afraid of. I know how this works. One foot. Then the other. The fear is information, not instruction. You don't have to obey it. You just have to keep moving.

The path to the front door is concrete now. It was brick. I know this without knowing how. Brick dust under shoes — small, shifting, scraping — I can hear it in my feet. The path is concrete but my body feels brick and my eyes see concrete and my feet say brick and I don't know which one to trust.

The front step is the same. One step up, wide, made of bluestone. I step onto it and the width is right and the height is right and my foot knows the placement the way a hand knows the shape of a childhood banister.

The front door is new. I knock.

Saskia opens the door.

She looks exactly the same — taller, sharper, older, but the same. Same dark eyes that miss nothing. Same short hair, same precise posture, same way of standing with her weight distributed evenly as if she might need to move quickly. She's wearing a pressed shirt at a weekend house. Of course she is.

"Neve." She says my name like she's verifying it. Like it's evidence she's cataloguing.

"Saskia."

We don't hug. We were never huggers, either of us. She steps aside and the hallway opens behind her and my breath stops.

The hallway is different — wider, lighter, renovated. Grey walls where there were — where there were — I don't know what colour the walls were. I don't remember. The hallway is different. Everything is different. New paint, new furniture, new everything. But the floorboards.

I step inside. The floorboards creak under my feet.

The same pitch. The same groan. Low and resonant, the way old timber speaks when weight finds its soft spots — a syllable the house has been rehearsing for twenty-five years, waiting for someone to walk across it again. The sound rises through my shoes and into my arches and up through my shins and into my chest and something there recognises it. My body remembers. My body knows this sound the way my feet knew brick, the way my foot knew the bluestone step. The floorboards creak with the exact note they creaked with twenty-five years ago and I know this because my body tells me and my body is not confused.

"Five minutes in the driveway. You couldn't decide whether to come in?" Saskia is watching me. Her eyes miss nothing. They never did.

"Fine," I say. "Just tired from the drive."

The word sits between us like it always does. Fine. The wall I build out of four letters. The answer that isn't an answer. The door I close between what I feel and what I say. Fine. Stop asking. Stop looking. It's fine.

I'm in the house. I'm standing in the hallway and the air is different here — warmer, thicker, carrying something underneath the smell of new paint. Something old. Salt and wood and the particular mustiness of a house that's been holding its breath between guests. Or maybe that's not what it is. Maybe there's something else underneath, something my body knows and my mind doesn't, something that was here before the paint and the carpet and the new furniture and will be here after all of it is gone. Something that has been waiting.

The hallway opens to the left where the living room used to be. Ahead, the staircase rises. I can feel it without looking at it. I can feel its presence the way you feel someone standing behind you — a pressure, a weight, a displacement of air that says something is there.

Saskia says something about the kitchen and I nod and I follow her voice and I keep my eyes on the floor and on the walls and on the back of her pressed shirt and I do not look at the staircase.

I don't look at the stairs. I don't look at the stairs. I don't look at the